Jesus and the apparent separateness of the Father.

During His life, Jesus was influenced by the appearance of things. Especially at the end of His life on earth and at the time of His ordeal leading up to the crucifixion. The appearance was, for Jesus, that He had failed in what He had come on earth to do. This is very much the way it seemed to Him. He had come into the world to free humanity from the powers of evil, yet it seemed that those powers still held sway—perhaps even more strongly than before. And so the Lord knew agonizing doubt and anguish. He had wanted so much to re-open the way to heaven and to heavenly living. He yearned for this. And now it seemed as if He had failed. That was the appearance.

We too are influenced by appearances. It appears that the world is flat but of course we know that it is not. It also appears as if the sun rises and sets and moves around the sky. Here again, we know this is not so, but that's the way it appears. As we look out on this world of ours it sometimes seems that this is all there can possibly be. This is the way it appears. We find it difficult to comprehend the existence of another world, the spiritual world, on another level or dimension of consciousness; and yet it is there. It also appears or seems at times that we can get along in life just as happily living for ourselves, selfishly, as thinking about others and caring for their well-being. As it is with such things as the sun apparently crossing the sky and the earth being flat, so it is where moral and spiritual issues and concepts are concerned. The appearances are very real and they impress us. But the appearance is not to be taken for the real thing.

It is in our times of temptation, as it was in the times of the Lord's temptations, that appearances, or how things seem, become so real. We are impressed by them and inclined to believe them. Indeed that's what temptation is all about. Do we give way to and accept what is only an appearance, or not? The appearance comes to us, at times, that the Lord doesn't care. We hear of some accident or tragedy, a child fatality or something like that. And the appearance that comes to us is of a God unmindful of such happenings. But do we accept the appearance or grapple with it and hold on to our conviction that He does care? The appearance is there on the one hand and our beliefs and convictions about a loving God are there on the other. There is a conflict between them and we must decide.

We live our lives influenced by appearances of the way things seem rather than in fact what they are. It has to be that way. We live our life influenced by the appearance that we live from ourselves. We also live our lives influenced by the appearance that, if He exists, God is remote, aloof, and distant from the hurly-burly of everyday life. In fact there are many such appearances which influence us while we live in this world. We can acknowledge, intellectually, that all life flows into us from God. In practice it doesn't seem like that. It appears otherwise. Indeed it has to appear like that because if we were conscious of the nearness of God and of our complete dependence on Him – really, openly, conscious, that is, – we wouldn't feel our life as our own; we wouldn't feel ourselves to be in charge of our own affairs.

So – and the point is important – necessarily we live with the impression of how things seem to be rather than what they actually are.

We said earlier that Jesus, while on earth, was influenced by appearances. He often spoke and acted as things seemed to be rather than as they actually were. And I refer here, in particular, to those occasions when He spoke about, and prayed to, the Father as someone separate from Himself. In Gethsemane He prayed to the Father as someone separate from Himself. From the cross He cried out, "My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken men?" And in His teaching, He often spoke in ways that suggested the Father as another, distinct personality.

The reality of the Incarnation is that God Himself, Jehovah, descended into the world, assuming or putting on human nature, both a human body and a human mind, that is, by birth of the virgin Mary. God Himself came. It is not as if He sent another. If then God Himself came why did Jesus speak of the Father as someone separate? Why did He pray to Him?

Before we start to answer that question, we need to look at another. Why did God come on earth? And the answer here is that He came to overcome the power of hellish beings and to restore free-will. And the only way He could effectively overcome infernal spirits was by successfully enduring temptation conflicts brought on by them. As He is in Himself above the heavens, God could not come into contact with the infernal beings and they on their part are and were quite unable to approach Him. So He veiled over His divinity. Covered it over by infirm human nature, so that there could be face to face combat with them. And the infernal beings were able to play on that human nature, stressing and emphasising appearances so that the reality of the situation was obscured in Jesus' mind.

We have just mentioned the 'reality' of the situation...What was that? The reality was that God was within Jesus. The Divine Love and Wisdom which is God was there within. And there were times when Jesus was fully and completely aware of this. In John's Gospel, chapter 14, we read, the Lord speaking:

> If you had known me, you would have known my Father also. From now on, you know Him, and have seen Him. Philip said to Him, "Lord, show us the Father, and that will be enough for us." Jesus said to him, "Have I been with you such a long time, and do you not know me, Philip? He who has seen me has seen the Father. How do you say, 'Show us the Father?' Don't you believe that I am in the Father, and the Father in me? The words that I tell you, I speak not from myself; but the Father who lives in me does His works. Believe me that I am in the Father, and the Father in me; or else believe me for the very works' sake. (Chapter 14, 7-11)

That, of course, is a very clear statement which we don't stop over often enough. To see Jesus was to see God Himself in human, bodily form.

But the reality, so clearly and unequivocally stated on that occasion, was sometimes obscured in Jesus' mind. Clear as it was on that occasion, it wasn't always clear to Him. The appearance of separateness returned. A cloud was, as it were, drawn over His thinking and He spoke and acted as if the Father, as if God, that is, were someone quite separate from Him. That's when He prayed. It was on such an occasion that He cried out from the cross.

The teaching given is that the Lord on earth alternated between awareness of who He actually was, on the one hand, and doubt and uncertainty about it, on the other. And were it not for the fact that He had those times of doubt and uncertainty He could not have been approached by the infernal beings and He would not have been able to overcome them. It's like with us. When we feel close to God, at peace with the world, and good about life, we are, so long as that lasts, safe from attacks from evil beings. When, however, we falter in our faith, and become unsure about the worth and purpose of life, feel disappointed about people, that's when infernal beings are able to play havoc and drag us down further. We alternate. At one time we are buoyed up and confident about the existence of God and the reality of the spiritual world and the importance of the Ten Commandments. At other times we are in doubt about all these things. And that's when temptations come to us. That's the opportunity the infernal beings have to get at us.

No more serious controversy has dogged the Christian Church, from its beginning, than that which has surrounded the relationship between Jesus and God. And the controversy is still with us today. Councils were called in the early days to try to resolve the issue. The Church has, sadly, divided over it. If we take the *Old Testament* first of all, we are left in no doubt that God is one and that the one God, Jehovah, would Himself come into the world. Such is the plain and unarguable teaching given there.

The difficulties have arisen, however, in connection with the *New Testament*, the impression being given there, that He who in fact came into the world was someone separate from God, a Son, a distinct and different personality. In a sense, and while the Lord was on earth, they were two personalities. God within, all-knowing, all-powerful, all-present, and the limited thinking of Jesus, influenced by appearances as we now know He could be, and was. But Jesus overcame and saw through the appearances. He rejected and put away the limited vision of things perceived by the natural mind, and made it possible for the Divine vision and wisdom to take its place. By the end, God who had incarnated into the human form, transformed it, so that divinity shone through.

We are, in a sense, two people and, hopefully, as the result of the process of regeneration, we will become one. We know in our hearts what are the ideals we should be living by and we speak in favour of them when we are with the right people. But there are also our very real inclinations to live selfishly and for ourselves and to reject and disobey those ideals. As time goes on, though, and if we make the necessary effort, those ideals we know about descend from our minds and memories into every part of our lives.

There is one God and He came on earth, 'putting on human nature' which, in the end, He made divine. Before that process was accomplished it was as if there were two. A sense of separateness was there. But that separateness went. It completely went. This is why, after His resurrection, and fully conscious and aware of things, Jesus could say that all power was His, both in heaven and on earth.